10.70711/rcha.v3i7.7826

An Initial Exploration of the Themes of Growth and Urban Life in Hou Hsiao-hsien's Films

Hanqing Zhao

Communication University of China, Nanjing, Nanjing, Jiangsu Province 211172

Abstract: This paper focuses on the themes of growth and urban life in Hou Hsiao-hsien's films, and analyzes its visual expression from three aspects: in the aspect of visualizing personal growth experiences, it transforms personal or others' memories into images to depict the life status and psychology during growth; in the aspect of family trauma and youthful memories, it conveys the impact of family atmosphere on individuals and the influence of environment on the emotional outlook of youth; in the aspect of modern urban life, it depicts the dilemmas of urban youth and cultural conflicts in transnational cities. With a calm perspective and delicate details, Hou Hsiao-hsien has constructed a unique style of thematic expression.

Keywords: Hou Hsiao-hsien; The Theme of Growth; The Theme of Urban Life; Visual Presentation

1. The Visualization of Personal Growth Experience

Hou Hsiao-hsien has repeatedly claimed that: *The Boys from Fengkuei* is his favorite movie. Although he was young when he shot the movie and could not understand a lot of things, he was full of energy and impulse. Now he is unable to keep hard-working as he did before."Notably, at the very beginning of his filmic career, he served as Lee's assistant director for Heart with a million Knots (1973), a highly successful adaptation of a Qiong Yao romantic novel. James Udden has called this period Hou's "strange apprenticeship " during which the future master learned the nitty-gritty of his trade in commercial cinema and eventually emerged as a 'leading director of the Taiwanese New Cinema in 1983'"[1].

It is a semi-autobiographical movie, and some episodes in the movie are the vivid memories of the director. For example, the hero Ah-Ching didn't work hard and always played with some rogues in the street, when his mother heard that she throw a knife angrily to him, and his leg was bleeding. This scene is a real memory of Hou Hsiao-hsien. He himself experienced a long period of confusion when he was young. Naturally, such a goof, ignorant and incompetent, person is unlikely to become an intellectual. After he entered the film industry, his inherent sensitiveness and kindness makes him become an outstanding artist. As the hero Ah-Ching in the movie, Hou Hsiao-hsien also lived in a small town and knew nothing about the world.

Ah Ching lived with his family in a narrow and damp house in a small town. They can only eat around a little table. His father always sat in the rocking chair in front of their house with empty and dull gaze into the distance. Because of the baseball injury when he was young, he suffered the permanent brain damage with a concave on his left forehead. He also lost the normal intelligence. There were flies flying around the dinner site which was Ah Ching's father's place, thus we can know their living environment was really bad. The mother asked Ah Ching to feed his father, while he was impatient and dropped the meal on his father. His mother scolded Ah Ching. We can know that the family atmosphere is really depressed from these details. The plots next completely record Hou Hsiao-hsien's love for girls in his adolescence. Ah Ching went to the beach with others, and he met a girl passing by. He talked to her, and then the girl played with them. Although Ah Ching liked the girl, he didn't dare to express his love for her. Ah Ching and Ah Rong came to Kaohsiung City and encountered Ah Rong's sister there. When they arrived in the apartment of Ah Rong's sister, she was taking a bath. She quickly wrapped herself up and opened the door for them. When she was talking to them, she also put away the dry underwear. These seemingly casual details are the results of observation of the young and sensitive Hou Hsiao-hsien. After the sister took them to see her boyfriend, the boyfriend was acted by Hou Hsiao-hsien himself. The guy who liked playing mahjong all the day always flirted with the sister and touched her thigh, but Ah Rong's sister did not mind. The life details were observed by the sensitive Ah Ching. Ah Ching desired for girls, thus he was interested in the details of men and women and observed it carefully. Although Hou Hsiao-hsien does not like to shoot fantasy of the leading roles, the audience must believe that Ah Ching had a certain desire and sexual fantasy for Ah Rong's sister. More importantly, there was a female character who was a neighbor of Ah Ching named Xiao Xing. She loved her boyfriend Jin He wholeheartedly. But Jin He was not nice to her and often yelled at her. Xiao Xing took good care of Jin He, while he ignored it and only cared for the evening school. He said that he stole the components from the factory for making money for

their wedding, but finally he abandoned Xiao Xing and left Gao Xiong. One day, Jin He was ready to go to the factory to steal industrial parts, and Xiao Xing quarreled with him. Ah Ching was washing clothes and watched the entire event. Another time Xiao Xing had a heated quarrel with Jin He, and Ah Ching stood watching them thoughtfully. Ah Ching had a crush on Xiao Xing because not only she was beautiful but also she was a symbolic unattainable sex life for young people like Ah Ching. When they had just moved into the next door to Jin He, they didn't see Jin He but Xiao Xing who just put away the dry clothes in the hallway. The three teenagers were very excited. Ah Rong said she was girlfriend of Jin He and he was envious of cohabiting couples. Ah Ching also said that Xiao Xing is much prettier than the girls in their town. The three boys didn't have a plan for their future, and the situation of cohabiting couples was their goal. The movie displays the sexual impulses and frustrations of the generation of Hou Hsiao-hsien by a lot of details from the male perspective.

They just came to Kaohsiung City, holding the cash of boyfriend of Ah Rong's sister and looking for a cinema. But they were cheated by a liar on a motorcycle. This is what every young people who just arrived in a big city will inevitably encounter. By the end of the film, Ah Ching helped Xiao Xing look for her boyfriend and even went to the house of Jin He's mother in the countryside, but he failed to find out him. Jin He's mother lived in a poor environment. She was cleaning the fish by a knife with many flies flying around her. We can know that the countryside in Taiwan at that time is very poor. But they were not aware of their poor environment and perhaps every rural family was poor. Xiao Xing couldn't find Jin He, but she didn't accept Ah Ching and went to Tai Pei. Ah Ching was disappointed and depressed, and then he would serve the army in the next few years. Before military service, he helped two friends do stall business. Ah Ching's father couldn't take care of himself, thus the role of father is empty in his life. We all know that Hou Hsiao-hsien's father died in his childhood, so his desire for his father is fully demonstrated in the film. The film is filled with a lot of personal memories and fragments of life details, completely displaying life experience of Hou Hsiao-hsien before military service.

A Summer at Grandpa's is the second art film of Hou Hsiao-hsien. It was selected as one of one hundred favorite films by the famous Japanese director Akira Kurosawa. The movie was adapted from a short story of the writer Chu Tien-wen. It can be said to show Chu's childhood memories. This time, the leading characters travelled from the city to the countryside, where they would spend their summer vacation. As the mother was very ill, Dong Dong and his younger sister Ting Ting had to be sent to grandparents' house to spend the summer. Their uncle took them there by train, but Ting Ting wetted her skirt and pants. On the halfway, the uncle got off the train with his girlfriend and missed the train when he got back, leaving Dong Dong and Ting Ting on the train. Fortunately, he finally found them in the exit of train station. The grandpa was very strict and unapproachable, and the personality was a bit similar to Hou Hsiao-hsien's father. Next are the life details of Dong Dong, Ting Ting and other children in the countryside. They played electric remote control car, played in the river undressed, the children in the village changed for Dong Dong's electric toy car by wild turtles. These scenes make viewers able to recall their own childhood memories and atmosphere in the countryside. But the grandfather was always stern and asked Dong Dong to learn. In addition, their mother didn't get better, which added an atmosphere of repression and the unknown to the pleasant experience. The following unexpected events took place that their uncle and his girlfriend secretly made love and resulted in premarital pregnancy. Ting Ting was playing near the railroad tracks and was narrowly killed by the train. She was rescued by a local insane woman named Han Zi who was discriminated by local people. The uncle hided a fugitive in the house and Dong Dong knew the secret and told it to grandpa. All these events occurred and then finished peacefully like this seemingly easy but actually heavy and depressing holiday. The film is obviously telling a story about children's growth not from the perspective of a child but from the perspective of an adult.

2. The Representation of Family Trauma and Youthful Memories

The Time to Live and Time to Die is an autobiographical movie of Hou Hsiao-hsien. The movie is basically his private memory of childhood and youth. Ah Hsiao witnessed three times of death of family members from childhood to youth, which had a great impact on Hou Hsiao-hsien. The three painful experiences will directly affect the formation of worldview and character of the young boy. Ah Hsiao's father was a junior official of Taiwanese ministry of education. He was not affectionate with their children, and he even deliberately evaded them. At home, he usually liked reading and writing and rarely talked to the children. After his death, Ah Hsiao knew that his father avoided them because he had lung disease for many years. But the illness cannot explain the apathy and depression of the family. His father's character is the main reason for the negative atmosphere of the family. His father was a stern, cold and not sentimental person. If he is humorous or sentimental, he will embrace his children even he has lung disease. The family atmosphere deeply affected Ah Hsiao. The style and characteristics of films of Hou Hsiao-hsien have been greatly influenced by his indifferent and depressed family atmosphere. The indifferent father had ultimately failed to overcome the disease and died on a calm night quietly. Soon later, his mother got the cancer. Once he had wet dream and got up at midnight to wash underwear, he heard his mother was crying and writing along the desk of his father. Because his mother knew she would die soon, while nobody could take care of the grandma of Ah Hsiao and the children were still young. She wanted to take the responsibility, but she didn't have the chance. At that time, Ah Hsiao have grown up and always played with the street hooligans all the day long. In his

mother's funeral, he could not help crying, which surprised his friends a lot. His grandmother was very old at the beginning of the movie, and she just sat in the house every day to cut paper ingots for her own ritual use. She was always thinking she just temporarily live in Taiwan and one day can return to the mainland. As she was old, she was confused and always took Ah Hsiao to walk in the countryside, hoping to get home on foot. After the death of Ah Hsiao's parents, nobody took care of his grandma and she never moved at home. When Ah Hsiao found his grandma was dead several days later, there were maggots on her body. It proves that although Ah Hsiao was a grown-up, he was not an adult with family responsibility and social responsibility and he did not know how to how to care for the elderly sick in bed. He did not know how to take the responsibility for the family. The three experiences of death are painful and depressing, but childhood of Ah Hsiao was not only painful experience. He played the wooden top with other children, stole the money from home and buried it under a tree, and then later he found the money was gone. When he grew older, he started robbery, gang war, smashing windows of billiard room with a brick with other hooligans. When it rains, he stood against the wall singing pop songs with the longing for love like other boys. He silently rode a bike after a girl he had a crush on and never dare to talk to her. One day, he delivered her a note and the girl said she would consider keeping a relationship with him after graduation. The real moments were shot by Hou Hsiao-hsien. In a word, Ah Hsiao's life from primary school to high school is actually that of Hou Hsiao-hsien.

Dust in the Wind is Wu Nien-jen's experience as a friend of Hou Hsiao-hsien. Wu Nien-jen is also the screenwriter of *Dust in the Wind* and *A City of Sadness*. In fact, he is not satisfied with this movie, because he felt that Hou Hsiao-hsien adapted the story into a too simple one and a lot of plots of real love had been deleted. Of course, this is the restatement by Hou Hsiao-hsien of his story, which is equal to re-creation. After all, the director is Hou Hsiao-hsien rather than Wu Nien-jen. Compared with *The Time to Live and Time to Die*, the movie is more simple and pure without not much depression and grief but touching. The theme of the film is still growth and love story of young people. Hou Hsiao-hsien shot out of his military experience in the movie. The hero Ah Yuan is silent and gentle; he is more like Wu Nien-jen than Hou Hsiao-hsien in terms of his personality. Ah Yuan is a young man living in a village, and his family live in a crowded and poor house. Ah Yuan's father broke his leg and couldn't work. There is no cruel death in the movie. Ah Yuan's father's leg injury is not very serious. Ah Yuan grew up with the girl Ah Yun and they liked each other. But they didn't become lovers. In other words, the relationship between the two of them is friendship between friends mixed with the feeling of crush rather than the relationship between lovers. They worked in Tai Pei. Ah Yun relied on Ah Yuan very much and meant to marry him in the future. But they never mentioned marriage and just lived together simply. Ah Yuan thought their relationship is reasonable, and the innocent idea laid a foundation for the following episode. After a period of time, Ah Yuan had to serve the army, and the relationship between them would be a severe test.

Ah Yuan serve the army and stayed in Kinmen. He often wrote letters to Ah Yun, she replied in the first year. But in the next two years, she never replied. And the letters sent to her were returned. Ah Yun who had loved him for a long time disappeared from his life. Later, Ah Yuan's brother told him that Ah Yun had married a postman. Ah Yuan was too sad. Although Ah Yuan finally saw the beautiful tranquil scenery in his hometown, he still could not heal his heart's sorrow. The sorrow is not as strong as the death of family members, but it will never disappear in people's heart. The sorrow due to the betrayal of lover in this movie replaces the emotions of grief due to the unforgettable death experience in *The Time to Live and Time to Die*. Lover's betrayal is more regrettable and sad than death of family members. Whatever people do will not change the fact but only can delay the process of their death. But the lover's betrayal can be avoided and will not happen definitely. If Ah Yuan and Ah Yun were engaged before his military service, Ah Yun will wait for him at home. A small behavior in one's life will change a lot of things in the rest of one's life. But it is regrettable that nobody can restart everything after he knows the result. Life is not film, and nobody can live again through time. Ah Yun liked Ah Yuan very much, but she married another guy after his military service, which was not further explained in the movie. The psychological motivation of Ah Yun is also not stated directly in the movie. But we can speculate that the reason why Ah Yun liked Ah Yuan so much largely is that they live in a remote and enclosed village. As for this point, we can see from another character: Ah Yuan's grandpa. The village is simple, quiet, aloof but extremely old like his grandpa. Ah Yun fell in love with Ah Yuan in such a closed, old and pure environment. However, once she came to the dazzling metropolis, her worldview and love will change greatly.

3. The Depiction of Modern Urban Life

The third theme of Hou Hsiao-hsien's film is about the confused life of contemporary young people as well as frustrated and depressed urban life. *Goodbye Southland, Goodbye* was named the top ten movies in 1990s by major magazines and movie critics. Like other movies of Hou Hsiao-hsien, the leading character is also the hooligan in the underworld. Gao is thirty years old and he was a hooligan before. He didn't wan to continue like this and began to think about how to make a living for a stable life and how to support his old father and build his own family. But he missed the golden age for accumulation of money. Therefore, before he returned to his hometown and began a new life, he was frustrated. The failure of career and marriage made him feel at loss. Biantou is the heeler of him and now he wanted to live a normal life with his girlfriend. However, Gao and Biantou suffered great difficulties in the society. He was insulted by the police and could do nothing but got angry. They have been unable to adapt themselves to the new well-ordered society.

Millennium Mambo was originally part of a huge series of films. Hou Hsiao-hsien planned to make a film about new changes in Taiwan every year since the new century. He wanted to make ten films from 2000 to 2010. But the plan was scrapped since the first one. He said that the changes in Taiwan were too fast to catch up with. We can see the ambition, frustration and confusion of Hou Hsiao-hsien from the original plan. The film focuses on the love story of a girl living in the big city Taipei. Vicky and her boyfriend Ah Hao lived together, but Ah Hao was very selfish and often regarded Vicky as his personal belongings. When she came home every day, he would check her bills, phone call records and text messages and even carefully smell her body to ensure she did not betray him. "Jealous of Vicky's financial independence, Ah Hao turns increasingly abusive, constantly checking Vicky's phone records or beating her. Finally, after several unsuccessful attempts, Vicky breaks up with Ah Hao." [2]

The relationship was not of equality and respect between two of them but occupation and the occupied. Once a stranger contacted Vicky, he felt that his personal belongings were looted. He would quarrel with Vicky just for a shopping list. Vicky couldn't tolerate him and left him. She met another guy named Jack and fell in love with him. He was an investor and kind to her. At that time, the shameless Ah Hao asked Vicky to come back. Vicky was confused at the two relationships. The film didn't achieve the success that Hou Hsiao-hsien imagined before since its release. Perhaps his artistically style is good at presenting the historical themes and cruel, miserable and depressed status rather than love and contemporary urban life. Another Chinese director Wong Kar-wai's art style is better at the performance of love and urban themes.

Coffee Time and *Flight of the Red Balloon* are the two films of Hou Hsiao-hsien invited by the Japanese and French movie studios respectively. As we all know, the major funding of Hou Hsiao-hsien's films comes from these two movie studios. It will surprise the viewers who are used to his film style. The characters no longer spoke Taiwanese dialects but Japanese and French. *Coffee Time* is a tribute to the famous Japanese director Yasujiro Ozu, and *Flight of the Red Balloon* is a tribute to Albert Lamorisse's movie *Le Ballon Rouge* in 1956. Tokyo and Paris, the two largest, the two most prosperous and the two noisiest metropolises during the history of mankind were recorded in the movies by Hou Hsiao-hsien in a special way. Hou Hsiao-hsien mentioned in the interview that his film style was different from Ozu who was good at the details of Japanese family structure. To pay tribute to Ozu, Hou Hsiao-hsien's movie also told a story of a Japanese family. Yoko is a Japanese girl born in a traditional family, but her idea is very avant-garde. She was pregnant when she was a teacher in Taiwan, but she told their parents in Japan that she was willing to give birth to the child when she returned home and the child did not need a father. The traditional father was not able to accept it, but he did not know how to communicate with his daughter. Time flied in silence. *Flight of the Red Balloon* tells the story between a French mother and a Chinese female student. Suzanne was busy with a Chinese puppet show, and her husband was writing a novel in the distant Montreal in Canada. "An homage to Albert Lamorisse's 1956 award-winning short, Hou Hsiao-Hsien's Flight of the Red Ballon (Le voyage du ballon rouge, 2007), departs from its titular French cousin not only through the addition of dialogue and a comparatively intricate plot, but also through depictions of specific forms of intercultural exchange: puppet theatre and overseas students." [3]

Nobody took care of their son, so Suzanne had to hire a Chinese student Song to take care of him. In Suzanne's room, Song was a spectator, quietly watching life and troubles of a family in Paris like the director Hou Hsiao-hsien himself does. One day, Suzanne's son Simon found an abandoned red balloon and played with the balloon happily. Song recorded it with a camera. Since then, the red balloon was magically floating in the place where Simon appeared. Hou Hsiao-hsien was not good at shooting the stories in Tokyo and Paris, but he could not prevent his own curiosity and could not help exploring the footsteps of contemporary urban living conditions.

4. Conclusion

From the analysis in this paper, it can be seen that the creation of the themes of growth and urban life in Hou Hsiao-hsien's films shows a trajectory from "private memory to public experience" and "local to transnational space". Taking life details as the anchor, the theme of growth embeds the pangs of growth in daily narratives, featuring both warmth and resonance; the theme of urban life extends from the dilemmas of local youth to the depiction of transnational cities, enriching the dimension of urban expression in Chinese-language cinema. His films are a record of the relationship between "individuals and the environment" — the creative method of calm observation and detail restoration has made his works "visual archives" of individual survival in the era, and also provided an important paradigm for the narrative of growth and the depiction of urban life in Chinese-language cinema.

References

[1] Hong, G. (2011). Taiwan cinema: A contested nation on screen. New York: Palgrave Macmillan. P88.

[2] Xu, G. G. (2007). Sinascape: Contemporary Chinese cinema. Lanham, Md. ; Plymouth: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers. P115.

[3] Metzger, S., & Khoo, O. (2009). Futures of Chinese cinema: Technologies and temporalities in Chinese screen cultures. Bristol, UK; Chicago, USA: Intellect. P14.